

Virginity

Someone is a virgin if they haven't had sex with another person before. The first time a person has sex, they are said to "lose their virginity."

What does it mean?

Virginity can mean different things to different people, because sex has different meanings for different people.

- People decide to first have sex at different stages in their lives and relationships. It's an important and personal decision.
- Some people define losing their virginity as the first time they have vaginal sex.
- Others define it as the first time they have oral or anal sex.
- Whether or not someone is a virgin has no bearing on their value as a person, whatever their age.



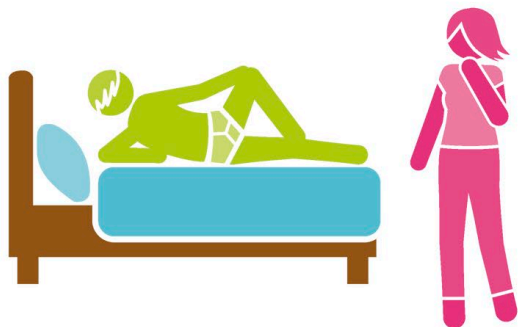
△ Different for everyone

You can't tell by looking at people whether they've had sex or they are still virgins.

Deciding to have sex

When someone feels ready, and trusts and feels comfortable with their partner, the experience is more likely to be enjoyable. Once both partners decide that they want to have sex, they can plan for it by choosing when and where to have sex, and arranging contraception in order to prevent sexually transmitted diseases (STDs) and pregnancy.

It's important to remember that most countries have a legal age to protect people from making the decision to have sex at an age when they may be too young. This age doesn't indicate the age that a person ought to first have sex—instead, many people wait until they're older and feel ready.



△ Making the decision

The most important thing about deciding to have sex is making sure that neither person feels under any pressure.

SEE ALSO

Consent	220–221 >
Sex	224–225 >
Safer sex	230–231 >
Contraception	232–233 >

TEEN HINTS

Talking to your parents

- When talking to your parents about sex, tell them the truth, and ask them to respect your decision.
- If they advise you not to lose your virginity, ask for their reasons. They may suggest something you haven't thought about.
- To begin a conversation about virginity, you might want to ask your parents how they would feel if you decided to have sex.

PARENT TIPS

Talking to your teen

- Make starting a conversation easier by letting them know you're open to talking about sex.
- Whether you agree with their decision or not, ensure your teen feels heard and understood. Explain that you want to be certain they've made an informed choice, free from pressure.
- Give them advice on the practicalities of safer sex, and the importance of using contraception to avoid STDs and pregnancy.